

Publishing Guide

Complete Beginner's Handbook — From Zero to Live App

This guide walks you through everything — account setup, preparing your APK, store listing, legal requirements, submission, and going live. No prior experience needed. Follow each section in order.

Developer Account	App Listing	Updates	Revenue Cut
\$25	FREE	FREE	15–30%
one-time, forever	no per-app fee	unlimited updates	only if you charge money

■ Your app is **FREE** so the **15-30% cut** does not apply to you.

Since 2048 Dark Edition is a free game with no in-app purchases, you pay nothing beyond the \$25 one-time signup.

What You'll Do — Big Picture

#	Phase	Time needed	Cost
1	Create Google Play Developer Account	15 mins	\$25
2	Build a proper signed AAB / APK	30–60 mins	Free
3	Create app assets (icon, screenshots)	1–2 hours	Free
4	Write a Privacy Policy	10 mins	Free
5	Fill in the Play Console store listing	30 mins	Free
6	Complete content rating questionnaire	5 mins	Free
7	Submit app for review	2 mins	Free
8	Wait for Google review	1–7 days	Free
9	App goes live — share the link!	Done!	Free

1

Create a Google Play Developer Account

One-time setup · \$25 · ~15 minutes

What is it?

Google Play Developer Account is like a license to publish apps on the Play Store. You pay \$25 once and it's yours forever. You can publish unlimited apps under one account.

1

Go to the Google Play Console

- Open your browser and go to: play.google.com/console
- Click **Sign In** at the top right
- Use any Google / Gmail account (create one free if you don't have one)

→ *Tip: use a Gmail you'll keep long-term — this becomes your developer identity*

2

Start the developer registration

- After signing in, click **Create Developer Account**
- Choose: **Personal** (not Organisation — you're building for yourself)
- Fill in your name and contact email
- Accept the Google Play Developer Distribution Agreement (click the link and read it)

3

Pay the one-time \$25 registration fee

- Click **Continue to payment**
- Enter your credit or debit card details
- Pay \$25 USD (charged once, account is permanent)
- You'll get a confirmation email from Google

→ *Note: payment may take up to 48 hours to be processed before account activates*

4

Complete identity verification

- Google may ask you to verify your identity (phone number, sometimes ID)
- This is normal — it's to prevent spam accounts
- Follow the on-screen steps to verify
- Once verified your Play Console dashboard opens — you're registered!

■ ■ Important

Do NOT use a temporary or shared Google account. Your developer account is tied to this Gmail permanently. If you lose access to the Gmail, you lose access

Build a Properly Signed App Bundle (AAB)

Google requires AAB format · Signing = your identity on the app

What is signing and why does it matter?

Think of signing like a wax seal on a letter — it proves the app came from YOU and hasn't been tampered with. Google requires every app to be signed before it can go on the Play Store. The Play Store also wants an AAB file (Android App Bundle) instead of a plain APK — AAB is a smarter format that lets Google deliver smaller downloads to users.

■ AAB vs APK

APK = one file for all phones. AAB = Google splits it into smaller pieces per device. Play Store requires AAB. Your personal sideload .apk still works for sharing

1

Open your project in Android Studio

- Launch Android Studio
- Open your 2048 project folder (File → Open → select 2048_project folder)
- Wait for Gradle sync to complete (progress bar at the bottom)

2

Generate a Signed App Bundle

- In the top menu: Build → Generate Signed Bundle / APK
- A dialog opens — select Android App Bundle (NOT APK)
- Click Next

3

Create your Keystore file (do this ONCE — keep it safe!)

- On the Key store path row, click Create new...
- Key store path: save it somewhere safe, e.g. Documents/my_2048_keystore.jks
- Password: choose a strong password — WRITE IT DOWN, you can never recover it
- Key alias: type my2048key (just a label)
- Key password: same as store password is fine
- First and last name: your name
- Country code: IN (for India)
- Validity: leave at 25 years
- Click OK

■ CRITICAL — Backup your Keystore!

The .jks file + both passwords = your app's identity. If you lose them you CANNOT update your app on the Play Store ever again. Back up the .jks file to Google

4

Build the release bundle

- Select `release` build variant
- Tick: Export encrypted key for enrolling published apps in Google Play App Signing
- Click `Next` then `Finish`
- Android Studio builds the AAB — takes 2–5 minutes
- Output: `app/build/outputs/bundle/release/app-release.aab`

→ *This .aab file is what you upload to the Play Store*

What assets do you need?

The Play Store listing is like your app's shopfront. Google requires specific images before you can submit. You can create all of these for free.

Asset	Size Required	How to make it	Required?
App Icon	512 × 512 px PNG	Android Studio or Canva	YES
Feature Graphic	1024 × 500 px PNG/JPG	Canva (free)	YES
Phone Screenshots	Min 2, max 8 320–3840px	Your phone or emulator	YES (min 2)
Short Description	Max 80 characters	Write it yourself	YES
Full Description	Max 4000 characters	Write it yourself	YES
Privacy Policy URL	A web link	Google Sites (free)	YES

How to Create Each Asset — Step by Step

1

App Icon — using Android Studio

- In Android Studio, right-click on `res` folder → New → Image Asset
- Icon Type: Launcher Icons (Adaptive and Legacy)
- Foreground layer: choose an image or use the built-in tile icon
- Background color: set to `#0D0D0D` (matches your dark theme)
- Click Next → Finish
- The 512×512 icon for Play Store: export via Image Asset → choose size 512

→ Or use [Canva.com](https://canva.com) — search '512x512 app icon' template, make it green/dark

2

Feature Graphic — use Canva (free)

- Go to: canva.com — sign up free
- Click Create a design → Custom size
- Enter: 1024 wide × 500 tall pixels
- Design it: dark background (`#0D0D0D`), big '2048' text in green, maybe a tile grid
- Keep it simple — just the game name and a visual vibe
- Download as PNG

→ This is the banner image shown at the top of your Play Store listing

3

Screenshots — take them on your phone

- Install your APK on your Android phone first
- Play a game to get the board looking good (some tiles filled in)
- Take screenshots: Volume Down + Power button at the same time
- Take at least 2–3: home screen, mid-game, stats screen
- Transfer screenshots to your PC
- Google needs them in portrait orientation for phone listings

→ Minimum 2 required, recommended 4–5 for better store presence

4

Write your Short Description (80 chars max)

- Example: "Dark-themed 2048 puzzle. Merge tiles, beat your best score!"
- Keep it punchy — this shows under your app name in search results
- Mention the key feature: dark theme, puzzle, 2048

→ Count characters at: lettercount.com

5

Write your Full Description (up to 4000 chars)

- Paragraph 1: What the game is (2048 puzzle, swipe tiles, merge to win)
- Paragraph 2: Features (dark theme, stats tracking, undo, PDF share)
- Paragraph 3: How to play (swipe in any direction, same numbers merge)
- Use line breaks between sections — no need to hit 4000 chars exactly
- Mention: no ads, no account needed, works offline, free forever

Why do you need a Privacy Policy?

Google requires every app on the Play Store to have a Privacy Policy, even if your app collects zero data. Since your 2048 app stores everything locally and has no internet, your policy will be very short and simple.

1

Generate a Privacy Policy automatically (free)

- Go to: app-privacy-policy-generator.firebaseapp.com
- OR go to: privacypolicygenerator.info
- Fill in: App name = '2048 Dark Edition'
- Developer name = your name
- Email = your Gmail
- Questions: tick NO for everything (no ads, no analytics, no personal data)
- Click Generate — copy the full text

2

Host the Privacy Policy online (free via Google Sites)

- Go to: sites.google.com
- Click + to create a new site
- Title the page: Privacy Policy — 2048 Dark Edition
- Paste in the privacy policy text you generated
- Click Publish (top right)
- Copy the URL of your published page — this is your Privacy Policy URL

→ Example URL: sites.google.com/view/2048darkprivacy/home

■ That's all for the Privacy Policy

Keep that URL saved — you'll paste it into the Play Console in Section 6. Your Google Site stays free and live forever.

1 Open Play Console and create a new app

- Go to: play.google.com/console
- Click **Create app** button (top right of dashboard)
- App name: 2048 Dark Edition
- Default language: English (United Kingdom) or English (United States)
- App or game: select **Game**
- Free or paid: select **Free**
- Tick both declarations (honest answers about policy compliance)
- Click **Create app**

2 Fill in the Main Store Listing

- In left sidebar: **Grow** → **Store presence** → **Main store listing**
- App name: 2048 Dark Edition
- Short description: paste your 80-char description
- Full description: paste your full description
- Upload your App icon (512×512 PNG)
- Upload your Feature graphic (1024×500 PNG/JPG)
- Upload your Screenshots (minimum 2 phone screenshots)
- Click **Save** at top right when done

3 Set App Category and Contact Details

- Scroll down on the same page
- App category: **Puzzle**
- Tags: add: 2048, puzzle, number, brain game
- Email address: your Gmail
- Website: optional (leave blank if you don't have one)
- Privacy Policy URL: paste the Google Sites URL you created in Section 4
- Click **Save**

4 Complete App Content section

- In left sidebar: **Policy** → **App content**
- Privacy policy: paste your URL again here too
- Ads: select **No, my app does not contain ads**
- Content ratings: click **Start questionnaire** (see Section 6)
- Target audience: select **18+** (safe, simple option for your puzzle game)
- News apps: **No**
- COVID-19 contact tracing: **No**
- Click **Save** after each subsection

Complete the Content Rating Questionnaire

~5 minutes · Just answer the questions honestly

What is content rating?

Like movies have G / PG / R ratings, apps have ratings too. Google walks you through a short questionnaire and assigns your rating automatically. For a simple puzzle game like 2048 you'll get the lowest (everyone) rating easily.

1

Start the questionnaire

- In Play Console left sidebar: Policy → App content → Content ratings
- Click **Start questionnaire**
- Enter your email address
- Category: select **Puzzle**

2

Answer the questions — all answers for 2048

- Violence: No
- Sexual content: No
- Language: No (no profanity in a number puzzle game)
- Controlled substances: No
- User interaction / social features: No (no online play, no chat)
- Location sharing: No
- Purchases: No (your app is free with no in-app purchases)

→ Answer NO to everything — it's a simple number puzzle game

3

Get your rating

- After answering, click **Save questionnaire**
- Click **Calculate rating**
- Your rating will be: **Everyone** (or PEGI 3 for European stores)
- Click **Apply rating**

→ Done! Your app is now rated for all audiences

Upload Your App Bundle & Submit for Review

The final step before going live

1 Set up your release track

- In Play Console left sidebar: Release → Production
- Click [Create new release](#)
- Google Play App Signing: click [Continue](#) to let Google manage signing

(This is recommended — Google keeps a backup of your signing key)

2 Upload your AAB file

- Click [Upload](#)
- Navigate to your AAB file: `app/build/outputs/bundle/release/app-release.aab`
- Select it and wait for upload (file is usually 5–20 MB, takes under a minute)
- After upload Google shows the file details — verify the version code is `1`

3 Fill in release notes

- Release name: leave default (e.g. "1.0")
- Release notes (What's new in this release):
- English text: "Initial release of 2048 Dark Edition.

Dark-themed puzzle game with stats tracking and PDF export."

- Click [Save](#)

4 Review and roll out

- Click [Review release](#)
- Play Console will show a summary and any warnings
- Fix any errors shown in red (warnings in yellow can usually be ignored for v1)
- Click [Start rollout to Production](#)
- Confirm by clicking [Rollout](#)
- ■ Your app is now submitted for Google review!

■ ■ What happens now?

Google reviews every new app manually. This takes 1 to 7 days for first-time submissions (usually 2–3 days). You'll get an email when it's approved or if changed.

1 Find your app's Play Store link

- Go to Play Console → your app → View on Google Play
- Your app URL will look like: `play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.personal.game2048`
- Share this link with friends — they can install directly from Play Store
- You can also search '2048 Dark Edition' on the Play Store app on any Android phone

2 How to publish an update

- Make your changes in Android Studio
- Open `build.gradle` and increase `versionCode` by 1 (e.g. 1 → 2)
- Also update `versionName` (e.g. '1.0' → '1.1')
- Build a new signed AAB (same process as Section 2)
- In Play Console: Release → Production → Create new release
- Upload the new AAB and fill in release notes
- Submit — updates review in hours, not days

3 Monitor your app

- Play Console → Dashboard shows installs, ratings, crashes
- Android Vitals shows if any phones have crashes — fix them in updates
- Ratings & Reviews: reply to reviews to show you care

→ *It's a free game shared with friends — you probably won't have many reviews*

4 What if Google rejects your app?

- You'll get an email explaining exactly why
- Common reasons: missing privacy policy, bad icon, incomplete store listing
- Fix the issue they describe → re-submit → usually approved next review
- Rejections are common for first submissions — don't panic, just fix and resubmit

Complete Pre-Submission Checklist

Go through every item below before clicking 'Submit for Review'.

Account & Legal

- ☐ Google Play Developer Account created and \$25 payment confirmed
- ☐ Google account you'll keep long-term is used (not temporary)
- ☐ Privacy Policy page published on Google Sites
- ☐ Privacy Policy URL saved and ready to paste

App Build

- ☐ Keystore .jks file created and backed up in 3 places (Drive, USB, email)
- ☐ Both keystore passwords written down and stored safely
- ☐ app-release.aab file built successfully from Android Studio
- ☐ AAB file tested by installing APK version on phone first

Store Assets

- ☐ App icon exported as 512×512 PNG
- ☐ Feature graphic created at 1024×500 PNG or JPG
- ☐ At least 2 phone screenshots taken (portrait orientation)
- ☐ Short description written (under 80 characters)
- ☐ Full description written (mentions dark theme, stats, offline, free)

Play Console

- ☐ App created in Play Console as a Game, Free
- ☐ Main store listing filled in and saved
- ☐ Privacy Policy URL added in App Content section
- ☐ Ads declared as: No
- ☐ Content rating questionnaire completed (all No answers)
- ☐ Target audience set to 18+
- ☐ AAB file uploaded in Production release track
- ☐ Release notes written in English
- ☐ No red errors shown on Review release page

Quick Reference — Important Links

What	URL
Google Play Console	play.google.com/console
Android Studio Download	developer.android.com/studio
Privacy Policy Generator	app-privacy-policy-generator.firebaseapp.com

Host Privacy Policy (free)	sites.google.com
Canva — free design tool	canva.com
Character counter	lettercount.com
Play Store policies	play.google.com/about/developer-content-policy